

Test	Pros	Cons
Flexible sigmoidoscopy	Fairly quick and safe Usually doesn't require full bowel prep Sedation usually not used Does not require a specialist Done every 5 years	Looks at only about a third of the colon Can miss small polyps Can't remove all polyps May be some discomfort Very small risk of bleeding, infection, or bowel tear Colonoscopy will be needed if abnormal
Colonoscopy	Can usually look at the entire colon Can biopsy and remove polyps Done every 10 years Can help find some other diseases	Can miss small polyps Full bowel prep needed Costs more on a one-time basis than other forms of testing Sedation is usually needed You will need someone to drive you home You may miss a day of work Small risk of bleeding, bowel tears, or infection
Double-contrast barium enema (DCBE)	Can usually see the entire colon Relatively safe Done every 5 years No sedation needed	Can miss small polyps Full bowel prep needed Some false positive test results Can't remove polyps during testing Colonoscopy will be needed if abnormal
CT colonography (virtual colonoscopy)	Fairly quick and safe Can usually see the entire colon Done every 5 years No sedation needed	Can miss small polyps Full bowel prep needed Some false positive test results Can't remove polyps during testing Colonoscopy will be needed if abnormal Still fairly new - may be insurance issues
Guaiac-based fecal occult blood test (gFOBT)	No direct risk to the colon No bowel prep	Can miss many polyps and some cancers Can produce false-positive test results